

Session 3: The Good Life

Key Takeaways

- The Greek word *makarios*, often translated as “blessed,” describes someone who has the good life, as seen from a third-person perspective.
- Being “poor in spirit” means lacking vital life-energy or being powerless.
- Jesus subverts cultural norms and common wisdom about who is truly blessed. It's not the powerful and wealthy, but those in need who have the good life.

Matthew 5:3-16—The Introduction

The introduction to the sermon has been given two simultaneously overlapping literary design structures. Seeing the introduction from both perspectives illuminates features of the speech.

Matthew 5:3-12

3 + 3 + 3 Good Life Sayings

- **5:3-5** **How good is life for** [the **social status** of the good life] theirs is **the kingdom in the skies**
 - The poor in spirit
 - The grieving
 - The unimportant
- **5:6-8** **How good is life for** [the **character** of the good life]
 - Those hungry for **righteousness**
 - The pure in heart
 - The merciful
- **5:9-12** **How good is life for** [the **conduct** of the good life]
 - The peacemakers
 - The **persecuted** for **righteousness**
 - **Y'all** who are **persecuted by people** for my sake

Matthew 5:13

Salt

- **Y'all** are the salt of the land
 - Be salty or be stepped on **by people**

Matthew 5:14-16

Light & City

- **5:14a** **Y'all** are **light** of the world
- **5:14b-15** A city on a mountain can't be hidden, nor a **light** put under a basket
- **5:16** **Y'all** let your **light** shine **before people**, so they can honor **your Father in the skies**

Matthew 5:3-16—Perspective 1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

From this perspective, the sermon's introduction consists of 12 key statements about the surprising identity of those experiencing the good life from Jesus' point of view.

The overall unit has been framed by an emphasis on the skies, with the opening "kingdom of the skies" in 5:3 and the closing "Father in the skies" of 5:16.

The nine good life sayings are shaped in three triads, based on thematic similarity, focusing on the **social status, character, and conduct** of those experiencing the good life.

- 5:3-5—the powerless, the grieving, the unimportant = **social status**
- 5:6-8—those desiring righteousness, purity, and mercy = **character**
- 5:9-12—those who make peace, do righteousness, and are persecuted = **conduct**

The ninth and final good life saying (5:11-12) is a hinge between the good life sayings that are stated as third-person plurals ("those who" in 5:3-10) and the three metaphors to follow, which are stated in second-person plural ("y'all" in 5:13-16).

Notice the introduction of those outside the Jesus community, who are hostile or looking on, the "people" (ἄνθρωπων) who are implied in 5:11-12 and explicitly mentioned in 5:13 and 5:16. Jesus is naming the response that his followers will likely receive within their communities. These notes frame the end of the first and last sections, as well as the middle.

Matthew 5:3-10

4 + 4 Good Life Sayings

- **5:3-6** **How good is life for** [the **social location** of the good life]
 - The poor in spirit
 - The grieving
 - The unimportant
 - Those hungry for **righteousness**
- **5:6-10** **How good is life for** [the **character** of the good life]
 - The pure in heart
 - The merciful
 - The peacemakers
 - The **persecuted** for **righteousness**

Matthew 5:11-12

9th Good Life Saying

- **How good is life for y'all**, when you are **persecuted** by people for my sake

Matthew 5:13-16

Salt, Light, & City

- **5:13 Y'all** are the salt of the land
 - Be salty or be stepped on by people
- **5:14-15 Y'all** are the light and the city on the hill
- **5:16 Y'all's** light needs to shine in front of people

Matthew 5:3-16—Perspective 2. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

From this perspective, the sermon's introduction consists of 12 parts that are bundled into three units.

- 5:3-10—eight good life sayings for “those who” (third-person plural)
- 5:11-12—one good life saying for “y'all” (second-person plural)
- 5:13-16—three metaphors for “y'all” (second-person plural)

The middle unit, 5:11-12, functions as a hinge that pivots between the eight good life sayings and the three metaphors.

- 5:11—picks up “How good is life for ...” and “persecution” from 5:3-10
- 5:11-12—also shifts from the third-person plural of 5:3-10 - into second-person plural that links forward to 5:13-16

The first four good life sayings focus on the **social location** of Jesus' followers (5:3-6), while the second group of four sayings focuses on their character and life practice (5:6-10). This links directly to Jesus' announcement of God's heavenly Kingdom that is arriving first for the poor and powerless (Matt. 4:17-25).

The ninth good life saying (5:11-12) is a hinge that repeats the main idea of persecution from the eighth good life saying (5:10) but shifts to the second-person plural address (y'all). This allows a smooth shift into the three metaphors in 5:13-16, which are all cast in the second-person plural. But even more, this hinge saying allows Matthew to introduce the theme of hostility toward the message of Jesus and his community that will be picked up in the next large teaching block (Matt. 10:5-43).

The three metaphors are adopted from the Torah and Prophets, where they describe the righteous remnant within Israel, those with whom God will renew the covenant to fulfill Israel's purpose among the nations.

Matthew 5:3-12—Nine Good-Life Sayings

Social Status

- ³ **How good is life for** the powerless,

because theirs is the kingdom of the skies .

4 How good is life for those who grieve,
because they will be comforted.

5 How good is life for the unimportant,
because they will inherit the land .

Character

6 How good is life for those who hunger and thirst for righteousness ,
because they will be satisfied.

7 How good is life for those who show mercy,
because they will be shown mercy.

8 How good is life for the pure in heart,
because they will see God.

Conduct

9 How good is life for the peacemakers,
because they will be called children of God.

10 How good is life for those who have been persecuted
on account of righteousness ,
because theirs is the kingdom of the skies .

11 How good is life for you all
when they insult you
and persecute you ,
and speak any evil lies against you
on account of me.

12 Celebrate and shout for joy,
because your reward is great in the skies ,
because this is how they persecuted the prophets before you all .

Matthew 5:3-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Interpreting the Beatitudes: What Are They Doing?

Key issues in understanding the Beatitudes

- What does “blessed,” here translated as “the good life,” mean?
- Why would Jesus begin with these, and how do they “announce the good news of the Kingdom of God” (Matt. 4:23)?
- What is the logic of these nine “How good is life for ... because ...” sayings?
- Why are there nine?
- What does each one mean by itself, and how do they relate to each other?
- How is their meaning deepened by studying hyperlinks to the Hebrew Bible and to Matthew’s entire narrative about Jesus?

Jesus begins by announcing *makarios*, “how fortunate/blessed/happy/flourishing are” By beginning the sermon this way, Jesus taps into a very biblical and Jewish way of talking about the ideal vision of human existence that is explored in the Sermon on the Mount.

Greek *makarios* (μακάριος) “ascribes happiness or flourishing to a particular person or state. A makarism is a pronouncement, based on observation, that a certain way of being in the world produces human flourishing.”

Adapted from Pennington, Jonathan T. (2017). [The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing: A Theological Commentary](#). Baker Academic. 42.

Makarios is the standard Septuagint Greek translation of the Hebrew word ‘*ashrey*’ (אשרי) Both of these words have been translated as “blessed” in the English tradition, leading to lots of misunderstanding about their meaning.

What Does “the Good Life” or “Blessed” Even Mean?

With this word, Jesus is tapping into the Wisdom tradition of Israel’s Scriptures. To fully understand Jesus’ meaning, we need to understand the Hebrew words and concept of “blessing.”

1. ‘*ashrey*’ (אשרי) = “happy/flourishing”

- This word is based on human observation and declares that a certain way of being in the world is a picture-perfect definition of “the good life,” a state of being that is desirable, and an image of true human flourishing.
- This word ‘*ashrey*’ occurs 45x in the Hebrew Bible (26x in Psalms, 8x in Proverbs, 11x elsewhere). Its etymology likely comes from either a Proto-Semitic or Egyptian root ‘*shr*’, meaning “prosperity, good fortune, happiness.”
- In the Hebrew Bible, the phrase “how good is life for...” is usually followed by an idealized state or behavior that is portrayed as desirable and as an example of the good life.

1 Kings 10:8 Instructor’s Translation

‘*Ashrey*’ are your people! ‘*Ashrey*’ are your officials, who continually stand before you and hear your wisdom!

Queen of Sheba to Solomon

Deuteronomy 33:29 NIV

'Ashrey are you, Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by the LORD? He is your shield and helper and your glorious sword. Your enemies will cower before you, and you will tread on their heights."

Moses about Israel

Psalm 32:1-2 NIV

'Ashrey is the one whose transgressions are forgiven, whose sins are covered.

'Ashrey is the one whose sin the LORD does not count against them and in whose spirit is no deceit.

David about himself and others

Psalm 128:1-2 NASB

'Ashrey is everyone who fears the LORD,
who walks in his ways.

When you shall eat of the fruit of your hands,

'ashrey are you; it will be well with you.

In these examples, the state of idealized goodness describes a state that someone is already in (like Solomon's courtiers or saved Israel or David's forgiven state, fearing the Lord), and they are being held up as an example of what constitutes the good life.

'Ashrey statements do not invoke God's blessing upon a person. Rather, they are a wisdom-based observation that certain behaviors or states are an ideal picture of what true God-centered human flourishing looks like.

Translation Note: The earliest complete English translation of the Bible, the Wycliffe Bible (late 14th century), rendered 'ashrey as "blessed." And it has stuck in the tradition until some of the 20th century translations that render "happy" (Christian Standard Bible; Common English Bible).

2. **barek/baruk** (ברך/ברוך) = "to bless/blessed"

- This word describes the gift of God's own life-presence that changes a person's life circumstances, resulting in abundance, fertility, security, and peace.
- This word is used 398x in the Hebrew Bible (327x as a verb; 71x as a noun).
- This word is used most often to describe how God declares or changes a person or group's life circumstances, resulting in abundance, fertility, security, influence, and peace. People can also announce or invoke God's blessing over others, but it is fully assumed it is God's blessing they are speaking over others (Example: the priestly blessing of Aaron in Numbers 6:24-26).
- The opposite of "blessing" is "curse": God declares or brings about circumstances of scarcity, instability, oppression, exile, or hostility.

Genesis 24:34-36 Instructor's Translation

So he said, "I am Abraham's servant. The Lord has **blessed** my master abundantly, and he has become wealthy. He has given him sheep and cattle, silver and gold, male and female servants, and camels and donkeys.

My master's wife Sarah has borne him a son in her old age, and he has given him everything he owns."

Deuteronomy 28:2-6 NASB

All these **blessings** will come upon you and overtake you if you obey the Lord your God:

Blessed shall you be in the city, and blessed shall you be in the country.

Blessed shall be the offspring of your body and the produce of your ground and the offspring of your beasts, the increase of your herd and the young of your flock.

Blessed shall be your basket and your kneading bowl.

Blessed shall you be when you come in, and **blessed** shall you be when you go out.

Deuteronomy 28:15-19 Instructor's Translation

However, if you do not obey the Lord your God and do not carefully follow all his commands and decrees I am giving you today, all these curses will come on you and overtake you:

You will be cursed in the city and cursed in the country.

Your basket and your kneading trough will be cursed.

The fruit of your womb will be cursed, and the crops of your land, and the calves of your herds and the lambs of your flocks.

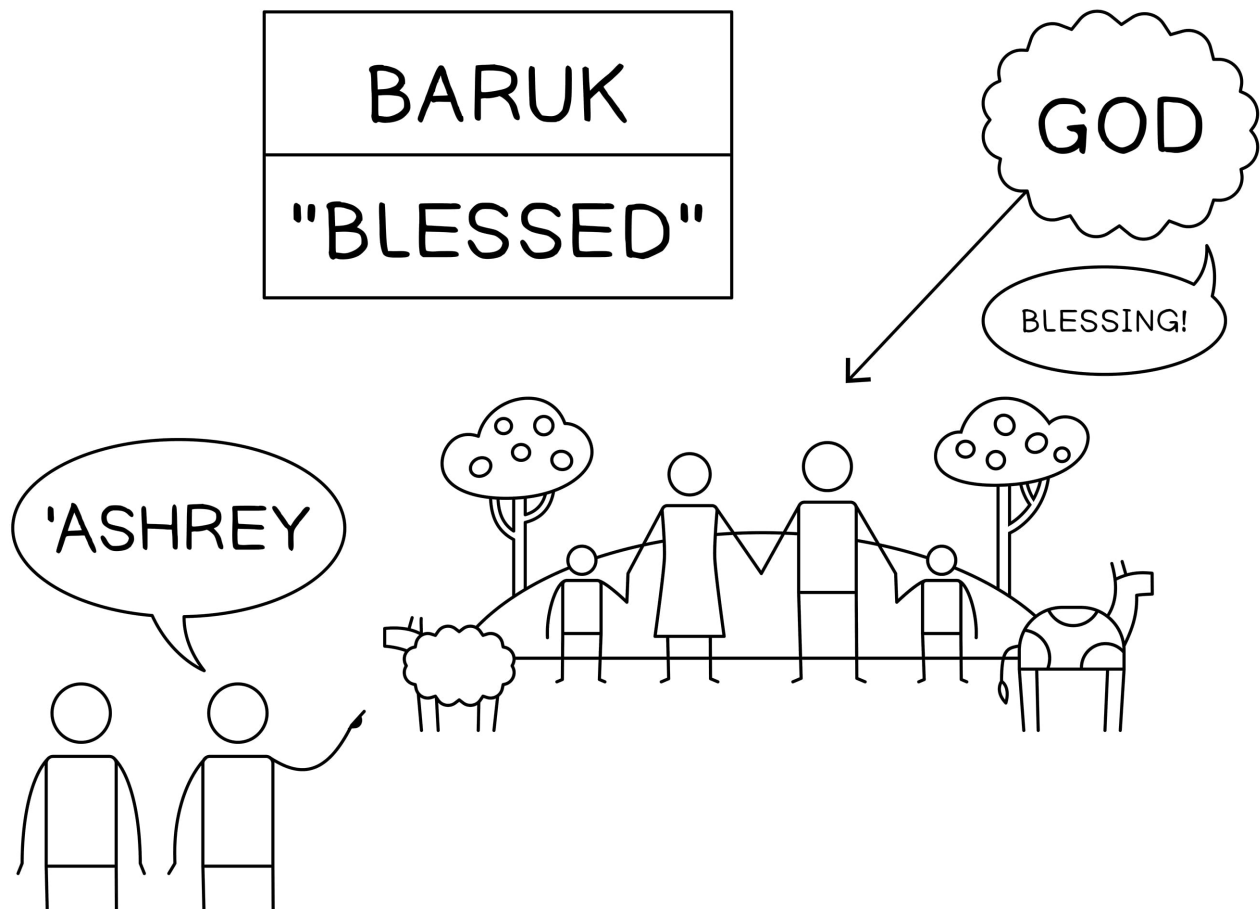
You will be cursed when you come in and cursed when you go out.

There is an important relationship between these two words, *'ashrey* and *barek*, but they are not synonymous. They do not mean the same thing, but they are connected (see Pennington's discussion, [The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing](#), p. 47-53).

- To be "blessed" is to receive from God's generosity life circumstances that are abundant and pleasant.
- When a "blessed" person's state of being is described by someone else, a third-party observer, and held up as an example or a desirable state, they are called *'ashrey*.

"*'Ashrey* is a description of the state of happiness, privilege, or fortune that is upon someone who is being observed by another, a bystander who is not the one who is providing or bringing about the blessing ... [In the Hebrew Bible] one never prays to become *'ashrey*. ... In contrast, *baruk* speaks of being empowered as the recipient of God's generous favor, because in biblical thought, all blessing comes from God alone."

Adapted from Pennington, Jonathan T. (2017). [The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing: A Theological Commentary](#). Baker Academic. 48-49.



Relationship Between 'Ashrey and Baruk. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

The state of blessing comes from God alone. One can definitely pray for or announce God's blessing upon another, but it is asking for a state of flourishing that only God can grant.

Being called 'ashrey is to take up the perspective of an outside observer, who looks upon someone else's "blessed" circumstances and declares that their situation is desirable, ideal, a picture of flourishing that others should find exemplary.

The opposite of 'ashrey is not "cursed," but a proclamation of woe.

- Matthew's nine *makarisms* that open [Matthew 5-7](#) (Jesus' first teaching block) are matched by his seven woes on the Pharisees in [Matthew 23](#) (the opening of Jesus' fifth and final teaching block).
- In the Hebrew Bible, we find that "woe" statements provide nearly identical contrast statements to Jesus' *makarisms*: These statements do not call down disaster upon people. Rather, they make a public pronouncement that the position of these people is not envious and exemplifies an undesirable state of affairs because of the terrible circumstances that are present or future or both.

Isaiah 3:11 Instructor's Translation

Woe (אוי / oy) to the wicked! It shall be go bad for him,
for (כי) what his hands have dealt out shall be done to him.

Jeremiah 45:3 Instructor's Translation

Ah, **woe** is me!

For the Lord has added sorrow to my pain ...

Hosea 7:13 NASB

Woe to them,

for they have strayed from me!

Destruction is theirs,

for they have rebelled against me!

Lamentations 5:16 NASB

The crown has fallen from our head;

Woe to us,

for we have sinned!

Ezekiel 24:6–8 Instructor's Translation

Woe to the bloody city,

to the pot in which there is rust ...

For her blood is in her midst ...

So that anger rises up to bring recompense ...

Why Does This Matter?

This distinction between *'ashrey* and *baruk* can help us understand why *'ashrey* statements are what they are.

Psalms 1:1-3 NIV

'Ashrey is the one
who does not walk in step with the wicked
or stand in the way that sinners take
or sit in the company of mockers,
but whose delight is in the law of the LORD,
and who meditates on his law day and night.
That person is like a tree planted by streams of water,
which yields its fruit in season
and whose leaf does not wither—
whatever they do prospers.

This is not a pronouncement of God's blessing upon this person, nor does the blessing bring about a state of flourishing. This person is already flourishing and experiencing the good life! The poet is advocating a certain way of life that results in being blessed by God, and holding it up as a model of human flourishing.

"Psalm 1 is ... an inspirational vision for the wise way of being in the world that will result in what all humans desire—human flourishing. It is a poetically crafted form of implicit invitation to consider the best way of being in the world and to pursue it. Like Proverbs, Psalm 1 offers a vision of human life ... that inspires them to live in such a way that will lead to it ... [*'Ashrey* statements] are an imaginative call to be a certain way in

the world not just because God demands it ... nor out of a mechanistic tit-for-tat view of God (read your Bible and don't hang out with bad people and God will bless you). Rather, this is based on an appeal to human flourishing for one's own sake."

Pennington, Jonathan T. (2017). [*The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing: A Theological Commentary*](#). Baker Academic. 52.

How To Translate 'Ashrey?

- Some scholars/translations keep with "blessing" (NIV, ESV, NAS, NRSV).
- The Latin title for these sayings, "Beatitudes," comes from *beatus*, which means "happy, blissful," not "blessed."
- Good options could be:
 - "How fortunate are ... " (But Fortuna is an ancient Roman goddess; do we really want to invoke her?!)
 - "How happy are ... " (But the English word "happy" refers primarily to an internal emotional state, not an internal and external state of affairs.)
 - "The truly flourishing are ... " (This could work, though "flourish" is not a common English word, and Jesus used a very common figure of speech to formulate these sayings.)
 - "Oh the good life of ... " OR "the good life belongs to" OR "the good life is for ... " OR "How good is life for ... "

Why Does Jesus Say That Undesirable States Are Actually True Flourishing?

Notice the logical structure of each of the nine sayings:

Matthew 5:3-8 Instructor's Translation

Oh the good life of those who ...
because ...

The first line involves a claim about who possesses the good life. The second line is the supporting evidence. This reveals a startling set of claims.

- How good is life for ...
 - The powerless, the mourning, the unimportant
 - Who long for justice and show mercy from a pure heart and seek peace
 - Who are mistreated and publicly shamed
- because ...
 - They are the ones reigning with God and who will inherit the new creation
 - They will find comfort, mercy, and their desires will be met
 - They will see God face to face like Moses and the prophets

Jesus is combining the Wisdom traditions discussed above with the Apocalyptic traditions of the Hebrew Bible.

An example of this is apocalyptic reversal. The biblical prophets all anticipated a time when the God of Israel would bring about a great reversal in history, when injustice and evil is confronted and judged and when those who are oppressed and forgotten will be vindicated and exalted.

Isaiah 65:11, 13-14, 16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹¹ But you who forsake the Lord,
who forget my holy mountain ...

¹³ Behold, my servants will eat,
but you will be hungry.
Behold, my servants will drink,
but you will be thirsty.
Behold, my servants will rejoice,
but you will be put to shame.

¹⁴ Behold, my servants will shout joyfully with a glad heart,
but you will cry out with a heavy heart,
and you will wail with a broken spirit. ...

¹⁶ ... Because the former troubles are forgotten,
and because they are hidden from my sight!

¹⁷ For behold, I create new skies and a new land;
and the former things will not be remembered or come to mind.

This is precisely the “new creation,” the renewal of God’s Kingdom, that Jesus claims to be ushering onto the scene in [Matthew 4:23-25](#). As he does so, Jesus reveals just how distorted and upside-down our social value systems really are. Jesus is upending our concepts of who or what kind of life counts as truly flourishing and in a state of being blessed by God.

This is closely connected to the Upside-Down Kingdom theme elsewhere in Jesus’ teachings.

- The last will be first, and the first will be last.
- The one who wants to lead must become a servant to others.

Jesus’ Beatitudes as Apocalyptic Surprise

Because *‘ashrey* statements express the speaker’s perception of what constitutes the good life, they are culturally contingent and can morph over time based on what a particular culture values.

As a result, these statements in the Hebrew Bible and in Jewish culture of Jesus’ day slowly began to create a two-tier system of Jewish piety.

Proverbs 3:13-18 Instructor's Translation

‘Ashrey is the one who finds wisdom and the man who gains understanding,
for her profit is better than the profit of silver and her gain better than fine gold.
She is more precious than jewels; and nothing you desire compares with her.
Long life is in her right hand; in her left hand are riches and honor.
Her ways are pleasant ways and all her paths are peace.
She is a tree of life to those who take hold of her,
and **‘ashrey** are all who hold her fast.

Wisdom of Ben Sira 25:7-11 NABRE

There are nine whom I would call **'ashrey**,
and a tenth my tongue proclaims:

'Ashrey is the man who can rejoice in his children;

'ashrey is the man who lives to see the downfall of his foes.

'Ashrey is the man who lives with a sensible wife ...

'ashrey is the one who does not sin with the tongue,

'ashrey is the one who has not served an inferior.

'Ashrey is the one who finds a friend,

'ashrey is the one who speaks to attentive listeners.

Greatest is the one who finds wisdom,

and none is superior to the one who fears the Lord.

4QBeatitudes (4Q525, lines 1-4)

[**'ashrey** is the one] ... with a pure heart, and does not slander with his tongue.

'Ashrey are those who adhere to the laws [of Torah], and do not adhere to perverted paths.

[**'Ashrey**] are those who rejoice in Wisdom, and do not burst out in paths of folly.

'Ashrey are those who search for Wisdom with pure hands ...

'ashrey is the man who attains Wisdom, and walks in the law of the Most High ...

The Beatitudes Are Apocalyptic-Wisdom Reversal Announcements!

Notice the contrast with Jesus' elevation of the poor, the afflicted, and those on the margins of society.

- Jesus offers a vision of the upside-down value system of the Kingdom. He is announcing who is "in" the Kingdom, and it's all the wrong kinds of people!
- Jesus here gives a radical revisioning of who are the people of God. Not the saints, or the leaders, or the Torah-teachers, or the Maccabean martyrs.
- The poor and unimportant who show generous mercy and who suffer, these are the kinds of people whom God favors and has invited into the new covenant Israel formed around the Messiah Jesus.

These are not the "be-attitudes," that is, commands to have a certain kind of "attitude." There is nothing inherently virtuous about mourning or being persecuted. Jesus is not telling us to cry all the time and make efforts to get persecuted.

Instead, **they are an announcement of reversal**, that people whose lives are marked by these negative and undesirable traits and circumstances are in the ideal place to discover the power and reality of God's Kingdom.

"Too often these characteristics [of the Beatitudes] ... are turned into ideals we must strive to attain. As ideals, they can become formulas for gaining honor and prestige, rather than descriptions of the kind of people to whom Jesus brings the Kingdom of God. Thus Jesus does not tell us that we should try to be poor in spirit, or meek, or peacemakers. He simply says that many who find themselves in such circumstances will surprisingly find that they have received the honor to be the first among those called into the kingdom."

Hauerwas, Stanley (2012). [*Hannah's Child: A Theologian's Memoir*](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 38-39.

The Beatitudes are reversals: They announce God's blessing on people who many would consider hopeless. They force the listener to revise, to expand and limit what kinds of people are "important" and have status in God's Kingdom.

The Beatitudes are, in fact, a poetic embodiment of the message of good news that Jesus quoted from Isaiah 61, connected to other important passages in Isaiah and the Psalms.

Isaiah 61:1-3 NIV

The Spirit of the Sovereign LORD is on me,
because the LORD has anointed me
to proclaim good news to **the poor**.
He has sent me to bind up **the brokenhearted**,
to proclaim freedom for **the captives**
and release from darkness for **the prisoners**,
to proclaim the year of the LORD's favor
and the day of vengeance of our God,
to comfort **all who mourn**,
and provide for **those who grieve** in Zion—
to bestow on them a crown of beauty
instead of ashes,
the oil of joy
instead of mourning,
and a garment of praise
instead of a spirit of despair.

Isaiah 57:15 Instructor's Translation

For thus says the high and exalted One
who lives forever, whose name is holy,
who dwells on a high and holy place
and also with **the crushed and those low of spirit**
in order **to bring life to the spirit of the low**
and **to bring life to the heart of the crushed**.

Psalms 34:18 Instructor's Translation

The Lord is near to **the broken of heart**
and saves those who are **crushed in spirit**.

Psalms 51:16-17 Instructor's Translation

For you do not delight in sacrifice, otherwise I would give it;
you are not pleased with burnt offering.
The sacrifices of God are **a broken spirit**;
a broken and a crushed heart, O God, you will not despise.

The Structure of the Beatitudes

These nine sayings have been designed in two overlapping arrangements.

Social Status

3 **How good is life for** the powerless,
because theirs is **the kingdom of** **the skies** .

4 **How good is life for** those who grieve,
because they will be comforted.

5 **How good is life for** the unimportant,
because they will inherit **the land** .

Character

6 **How good is life for** those who hunger and thirst for **righteousness** ,
because they will be satisfied.

7 **How good is life for** those who show mercy,
because they will be shown mercy.

8 **How good is life for** the pure in heart,
because they will see God.

Conduct

9 **How good is life for** the peacemakers,
because they will be called children of God.

10 **How good is life for** those who have been **persecuted**
on account of **righteousness** ,
because theirs is **the kingdom of** **the skies** .

11 **How good is life for** **you all**
when they insult **you**
and **persecute you** ,
and speak any evil lies against **you**
on account of me.

12 Celebrate and shout for joy,
because **your** **reward** is great **in** **the skies** ,
because this is how they **persecuted** the prophets before **you all** .

The literary features that point toward two sets of four are as follows.

- There are eight statements that begin with the identical phrase “the good life belongs to ... ” (*makarios hoi ...*).
- Statements one and eight have an identical ending “because theirs is the kingdom of the skies.”
- The ninth is clearly linked to the preceding eight, but also different: “the good life is for y’all ... ” (*makarios este*).
- The eight statements are identical in form, while the ninth breaks the pattern but expands the content of the eighth.
- Both speak of persecution on account of the skies.
- Each set of four sayings has exactly the same number of Greek letters (see Dale C. Allison Jr., [Studies in Matthew](#), p. 174-175).

The meaning of two sets of four:

- Sayings one through four promise a reversal for the poor and unfortunate, while sayings five through eight promise rewards for the virtuous (Mark Allan Powell, [God with Us: A Pastoral Theology of Matthew's Gospel](#), p. 119-140).
- Sayings one through four pertain to loving God, while sayings five through eight pertain to relationships with other people (David Garland, [Reading Matthew: A Literary and Theological Commentary](#), p. 54).
- Sayings one through four explore the mindset and attitudes of the righteous, while sayings five through eight focus on relational conduct of the righteous (William Dumbrell, [The Logic and Role of the Law in Matthew 5:1-20](#) p. 4).

3 + 3 + 3—Three sets of three

- This is a common rhetorical communication technique in ancient Jewish literature. Bundling things into threes makes them easy to remember and allows effective use of parallelism, similarity, and contrast.

The literary features that point toward three sets of three are:

- There are technically nine makarisms, each beginning with *makarioi*.
- The third of the third set is climactic, taking up the ideas of the eighth but also developing them.
- The last of the nine is a link-hinge, binding the makarisms to the three images that follow about the salt/light/city.

Scot McKnight points out that sayings one through three focus on the humility of the poor (poor in spirit, mourners, the meek), sayings four through six focus on those who pursue justice (those who desire justice, the merciful, the pure in heart), sayings seven through nine focus on those who create peace (peacemakers, persecuted, the insulted). The three moral themes are humility, justice, and peace (McKnight, [Sermon on the Mount](#), p. 37-38).

- Sayings one through three: **Their social status**—The powerless, those who suffer loss, and those of low social status.
- Sayings four through six: **Their character**—They long for justice, they're merciful, and they have a single desire (for God).

- Sayings seven through nine: **Their conduct**—They make peace, they're persecuted, and they're rejected for doing justice.

Reflection Question

What does it mean to be "poor in spirit"?